

Beyond Dollars: Unveiling the Deeper Layers of Online Romance Scams Introducing “Body Scam”

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ABSTRACT

As online romance surges, so does the popularity of online romance scam. While existing research predominantly emphasizes financial scams, our study introduces “body scam” which is not for financial gain, but just for sexual abuse. We conducted interviews with 20 victims of online dating fraud with sexual scam experience in Iran, delving into their story in a context where dating is legally, socially, and normatively complex. Through inductive coding, our findings reveal a notable shift in victimization risks, particularly for women, with a growing emphasis on predatory sexual intent rather than purely financial motivation. This study not only sheds light on the evolving landscape of online dating risks but also underscores the significance of understanding the nuances of sexual intentions in the Iranian context.

CCS CONCEPTS

• Security and privacy; • Software and application security; • Social network security and privacy;

KEYWORDS

Online Romance Scam, Online Dating Fraud, Sexual Intention, Sex-tortion, Body Scam, Iran

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1 INTRODUCTION

Trigger Warning: This paper addresses sensitive subjects like sexual abuse, which could potentially evoke strong emotional reactions.

For people in search of a romantic relationship, the internet expands geographical possibilities and allows for a more flexible

or playful approach to social identity [1], [2]. The negative consequences of these enhanced possibilities, including an increase in online romance scamming, are slowly leading to the recognition of the associated risks in this environment. This type of relationship and trust fraud often has both a financial and an emotional impact on the victims [3], [4], [5]. For most victims of online dating fraud, the loss of a relationship is even more upsetting than the financial impact [6]. Moreover, while the financial impact of online romance scams is quantifiable and well reported, there is less literature on sexual abuse [7]. Addressing this research gap, we argue that the definition of “online romance scam” should be modified to include a new stage that elaborates on fake daters, who establish trust solely for sexual gain, rather than financial. Our main research question, then, is: “**How prevalent is sexual predation in online romance scams in a non-Western context, and should we then redefine our terms?**”. This preliminary qualitative study provides initial insights into the deeper layers of online dating scams in a non-Western context. In the future, we would like to further develop the concept of a “body scam” by conducting more extensive research on online romance scams in non-Western contexts, where premarital relationships are considered unacceptable.

2 BACKGROUND

2.1 Definition of Online Romance Scam

HCI Researchers have been studying safety and privacy in technology [8], [9], [10], [11], [12], [13], [14], [15], [16], [17], [18], [19], [20], [21] for some times. Extensive literature has highlighted the risks associated with online dating. There are some well-known definitions of the online romance scam that are similar. With respect to fraud, Beal [22] and Garrett [23] define online romance scams as a type of relationship and trust fraud where a person or a group of people only pretend to engage in a romantic relationship with a user via social media or online dating websites and applications [23], [24], [25]. The scam can include deception, sexual violence and financial fraud. Hancock et al, [26] discuss deception and lying in online dating profiles. Hancock and Toma [28] show the motivations for deception are many and varied. Furthermore, Toma’s study reveals that humans often struggle with detecting deception [27]. This is often due to a natural bias towards assuming others are trustworthy, leading to misclassifications, even when information varies [28]. Online romance scams are not limited to dating apps or websites; they also occur on social media platforms like Facebook [30].

*Place the footnote text for the author (if applicable) here.

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2.1.1 Different Stages. Existing studies elaborate these seven stages for online romance scam [7], [29], [30], [31], [32]: **Stage1:** Motivated to find the ideal partner: Participants, both those actively seeking relationships and those not, expressed a shared desire to find their ideal partners on the site, with varying relationship expectations and backgrounds. **Stage2:** Presented with the ideal profile: All participants, both those financially affected and not, described the “fake profiles” presented by the criminal as embodying an ideal person tailored to their individual preferences, often featuring physically attractive photographs; these profiles typically had characteristics appealing to the gender-specific partner preferences commonly observed in research. **Stage3:** Grooming process: In this stage, referred to as the grooming stage, victims’ vulnerability is assessed to determine whether they will become financial or non-financial victims, drawing parallels with how sexual offenders groom children. Scammers build trust with victims through ICTs, offering a safe space for personal disclosure and developing a close online relationship, leveraging the excuse of living abroad to buy time. This “hyperpersonal” connection is fortified through romantic emails and IM chats, making it harder for victims to disengage. ICTs leave a record, reinforcing the romantic messages, and the stage may culminate with the scammer testing the victim’s compliance for a gift before moving on to various routes in the next stage. **Stage 4:** The sting: In this stage, the criminal begins soliciting money from the victim, utilizing tactics like the foot-in-the-door technique or fabricating a crisis. If the victim has been successfully groomed, they comply with monetary requests; otherwise, they may attempt to end the relationship, prompting the criminal to return to Stage 3 to continue grooming. Some victims manage to successfully exit, with their resilience not solely dependent on their knowledge of the scam, as adept grooming can still deceive victims into trust. **Stage 5:** Continuation of the scam: In this stage, the criminal uses the door-in-the-face (see Ref [29]) technique on non-compliant victims, leading to a cycle of new crises or small money requests until victims run out of funds, exit the scam, or become aware of the deception, often with law enforcement’s involvement. **Stage 6:** Sexual abuse: In some instances, when victims had no money left to give, they were pressured to engage in webcam sexual acts, even without seeing the other person on the camera. This later became a blackmail tactic, with threats to share the recorded videos with the victims’ work and family, leaving victims feeling deeply embarrassed and ashamed despite their initial reluctance. **Stage 7:** Re-victimization: at this point, most victims skip Stage 6. Typically, victims informed by law enforcement often fell back into the scam, either with the same or a new scam. Those returning to the same scam encountered additional money requests for various reasons, such as being told by the scammer that they had genuinely fallen in love, leading to further financial demands.

2.2 Sexual Abuse and Violence

Romance scammers can forge a special emotional and sexual connection, heightening their impact on victims [33]. Scammers create relationships, stage crises, and may use recorded sexual acts for blackmail [34]. However, Edmond Pui’s research in Hong Kong demonstrated that sexual abuse saw an increase in 2018 [35]. The study highlights that unprotected or unwanted sexual encounters

resulting in pregnancies were common issues associated with dating app use. Predators seeking sex swiftly move from online chats to in-person meetings for sexual purposes [36], [37], [38]. Powell, Flynn and Henry [39] contend that advancements in communication technology have opened doors for sexual violence, encompassing various forms such as non-consensual sharing of explicit images and online harassment, including sexual solicitation, image-based harassment, gender-based hate speech, and threats of sexual violence. A recent research paper explored different manifestations of online sexual abuse, including sextortion, sexting, catfishing, and rape. The authors of the paper also highlight the limited research on sexual abuse, despite it being a prevalent issue in online dating [36]. Sextortion, frequently employed by scammers, involves using sexual abuse as a means to extort money [29], [32]. This issue seems to be on the rise [40], [41]. These scams primarily rely on social engineering techniques (refer to [42], [43], [44]), inflicting financial, emotional, and psychological distress on victims, leading to feelings of shame, anger, stress, and, in some cases, even suicidal thoughts [3], [6], [45].

2.3 The Role of the Internet on Dating Life in Iran

In situations where control extends to clothing, entertainment, education policies, and social interactions [46], cyberspace offers a potential avenue for liberation [47]. This newfound freedom can also be harnessed for clandestine romantic relationships, which are easier to maintain online [47]. Technology’s influence on premarital relationships is evident, particularly among adolescents with access to technology and the internet (e.g., mobile phones, social media), as they engage in more romantic relationships before marriage [48]. This underscores the younger generation’s comfort in using cyberspace to circumvent cultural and legal constraints [49]. While Iranians seem to privately embrace Western dating practices, premarital relationship are socially taboo, and against the law. Therefore, Iranian culture serves as an example of a non-Western society where individuals turn to covert relationships to evade legal and social repercussions.

3 METHODOLOGY

3.1 Recruitment

Considering that conventional Western dating applications (e.g., Tinder and Bumble) are banned in Iran, we chose two of the most popular publicly available social media platforms used for dating practices: Instagram and Telegram. This choice was influenced by the absence of alternatives in Iran and these platforms’ popularity, as noted by our participants. The recruitment occurred in two phases: Initially, we used an existing Instagram account related to the topic of online romance, with 11,000 followers (Based on Instagram account statistics’ information: 58.9% Female, 41.1% Male), ranging in age from 13 to 65 years and located in Iran, covering both rural and metropolitan areas. Our sole recruitment criterion was previous experience with romance scams in cyberspace. The second phase of recruitment was conducted through a public Telegram channel accessible to all, with approximately 94,000 members. Unfortunately, Telegram does not provide statistics on members’ gender, age, or location. Ultimately, our sample consisted of 20

participants (17 females and three males) aged between 14 and 36 at the time of the incident. No financial compensation was offered to the participants.

3.2 Interview

We conducted narrative interviews [50], allowing participants to freely and easily share their experiences without our interruption. They were informed about our research question, consented to data use, and shared their stories, focusing on their relationship experiences. During the interviews, we asked participants to share their experience with online dating scams, we only asked supplementary questions at the end of their stories if necessary. For example, ‘What did he/she steal? What were the benefits of this fake relationship? Why do you think it was a romance scam rather than just sexual abuse?’. Interviews were carried out remotely using voice calls, messaging, and text, lasting anywhere from 40 minutes to 2.5 hours. This variation in duration reflects the depth of experiences among participants, some of whom have nurtured their relationships for more than two years and had substantial insights to share. Interviews were conducted in Persian, later transcribed into English for analysis, ethical approval obtained from the university’s ethics board.

3.3 Ethical Considerations

Ethical approval was obtained from the university’s ethics board. Given the sensitivity of the topic we considered several policies to protect our participants and prevent participants’ re-victimization: a) protecting anonymity: we used pseudonyms and respected interviewees’ privacy by not disclosing real names or locations, b) secure data handling: we collected data on an offline device, removed identifying information, and offered participants the option to delete chat conversations after the interview, c) flexible interview process: we accommodated preferences for text or audio interviews, including late-night sessions, to ensure privacy and comfort, d) follow-up questions: we messaged participants discreetly without referencing the interview subject. We initiated contact with a simple greeting, awaited their response, and prioritized their safety and comfort, e) trauma during the narration: we approached traumatic experiences with caution, acknowledging potential emotional impacts, emphasizing active listening, empathy, and motivation for participation, while some found the interviews emotionally intense, leading one participant to opt out [51], [52].

3.4 Data Analysis

We employed qualitative content analysis (QCA), a methodology often used in qualitative studies [53], [54], with MAXQDA software. The lead author conducted multiple readings to establish initial codes and themes, and afterwards other authors refined the identified themes and added new ones in the presence of lead author. In total, five themes were identified: “Dating practices”, “Vulnerabilities”, “Intention of dating”, “Sexual Abuses”, and “Coping strategies”. In this preliminary work we only focus on one main theme: “Sexual Abuses”.

4 FINDINGS

Participants reported two types of scams, including those that remained within the realm of cyber space and those that led to real-world sexual abuse experience. Table 1 shows this categorization:

4.1 Sexual Intention as Goal of Attack: Call It Sexual Scam

In our sample, notably, sexual abuse was a very significant feature for female victims. Emotional and psychological pressure was a by-product of the most prevalent issue, the quasi-ultimate goal of the fraudsters, which turned out to be sexual abuse. Participants spoke of their dater having fooled them just for sexual benefit. P11 explains this as: “After our sex, he stopped our relationship.”

Thirteen of the participants had sexual abuse experience ranging from sexting to sextortion, from rape to pregnancy. In the following subsections we describe these categories of the sexual abuse experience.

4.1.1 Sexting. Sexting (sending and receiving (semi-)pornographic images, video, and/ or texts online) can be used as a way of abusing users in cyberspace by urging them to participate and follow the offenders’ commands. In the different cases, the offenders pressured their victims psychologically, threatening to leave them. This way, P2, P19, P18, P17, P13, P6, and P7 were pressured to expose themselves and participate in “sexting”:

“He asked for some nude photos, but I refused. At this point, his behavior suddenly changed, and he began to threaten me.” (P7)

All participants saw themselves victims of sexual abuse, emotionally pressured to stay in the relationship. In the case of P6, the scammer pushed her to participate in sexting ranging from text to photos, from video to phone calls:

“He also abused me sexually. He used to ask for sex chat, voice or video call all the time. [...] I did not like to have sex chats or video calls but after some months I did not want to lose him and did whatever he asked for.” (P6)

However, in case of P19, it was more complicated. At first, she was participating in sexting willingly by sharing some intimate photos and videos. Then, the offender abused her by pressuring her to continue. P19 was threatened that if she stopped following him and providing him with images, the scammer would call her father.

“He told me I should send my naked photo to him[...] When I ignored his request, he called my father but didn’t say anything! He called to make me feel scared” (P19)

4.1.2 Sextortion. Three other participants, P19, P10 and P9 experienced scammers threatening to release intimate information such as photos unless they follow the predators’ commands. In P19 and P10’s case, the scammer convinced them to send some intimate photos. Then, offenders threatened the victims to call their father and send all intimate photos to them if they did not send more nude pictures and videos or even worse, have physically sexual relations in the real world. Although, P19 did not accept real-world sex, the

Table 1: Participants Who Have Experienced Sexual Abuse

Participants	Cyber-Sexual Abuse	Real-World-Sexual Abuse
P ₁ (1-20)	P2, P6, P7, P9, P17, P19	P3, P10, P11, P12, P16, P18, P20

scammer pushed her to perform some sexual acts during a video call:

“He told me that I had to go to the bathroom and during a video call to [Censored by authors (some sexual activities that damaged herself)], otherwise he would call my father and share my intimate photos and videos with him” (P19)

P10 also reported that, after the incident, the scammer threatened to publish a videotape of the incident. She was asked to send him money to prevent the release.

“He threatened me that if I do not give him the money he asked for, he would share this video on social media!” (P10)

This participant (P10) was our only case in which sextortion was accompanied by a demand for financial gain.

4.1.3 Unwanted Sex and Rape in Real World. Transferring from online to offline dating was a tactic of offenders who had the goal of real-world sex. After the offenders established a trustful relationship, they asked to have a face-to-face meeting in (semi-)private places (e.g., their house, or office). Five participants (P10, P3, P11, P16 and P20) had a date at the scammers’ places. All experienced sexual abuse physically in their first face-to-face date.

“After one month of chatting with that guy, we decided to have a real-world date [...] he hugged me, kissed me, and put me under sexual pressure.” (P3)

Daters like P16 were more committed to their relationships. For older participants like her, dating with the goal of marriage was common. She believed that meeting in person was a natural step in this context, but she was taken aback by what she encountered.

“I wanted to find an appropriate partner for marriage [...]. We talked on the phone several times [...]. Afterwards, we decided to have an offline dating in his office (after working hours) [...]. Suddenly, I saw he entered the room totally naked! I was shocked!” (P16)

Additionally, fear of being seen in public was a factor in both P3 (unwanted sex and pregnancy) and P10’s experience (rape). In the latter case, the scammer asked to have an offline date after six months of the online relationship. Since she lives in a small city, she accepted his suggestion of having their first date at his place.

“He suggested meeting in person. Since I live in a small city where it’s not acceptable to have a boyfriend or go out with a boy in our local culture, I chose to meet him in his city [...]. then I went to his place [house]. [...]. We were talking, and suddenly, his friends entered and then came to me at once and raped me!” (P10)

5 DISCUSSION AND CONCLUSION

5.1 How the Concept of Pre-Marital Relationship/Sex is Different in Iran?

This exploitation of societal taboos against premarital sex is a notable feature of the current study. The literature has much to say about online dating risks, but almost entirely in the context of the West (apart from some studies e.g., [55], [56], [57], [58], [59]). The results of previous studies and our findings show that scammers’ strategies for establishing trust are, for the most part, the same in western cultures and in Iran, despite differences between dating cultures, norms, laws, and traditions. One of the major risk factors stems from the prevailing social norms and values. Premarital relationship is prohibited, seen as a religious transgression, and a pervasive social taboo. This profoundly affects daters’ safety because involvement in premarital relationships places them at risk of legal repercussions. Sex is typically accepted in Western relationships [38], and efforts to improve sexual risk detection in online dating have been directed towards this goal [60], [61]. In order to stop non-consensual sexual activity, they suggest remedies like the idea of consent for sex when dating online and systems that facilitate the exchange of consent [62], [63], [64], [65]. Premarital sex is still forbidden both legally and culturally in places like Iran. Moreover, the fear of severe consequences, especially within their families, compels daters to keep their activities secret, resulting in unsafe practices such as rendezvousing in secluded areas or visiting unfamiliar homes alone, which poses a particular threat to women’s safety. In other words, as Ruggi [66] has noted, “A woman’s virginity is the property of the men around her, first her father, later a gift for her husband; a virtual dowry as she graduates to marriage”.

5.2 Sextortion for More Sexual Gain, Not Financial

We argue that detection and awareness of sexual abuse comes with different indicators than those in financial extortion. In Iran, engaging in sexual activities within romantic relationships is uncommon due to legal and social risks. Our participants described a scam where trust is built through promises of marriage and emotional pressure, aimed at coercing victims into sexual activities, often forcibly. Some cases of sextortion were also reported, not for monetary gain but to pressure victims into further sexual involvement. This unique aspect, which we call ‘Body scams,’ is more significant than ‘Money scams’ [67] in this cultural context. So, we introduce the concept of ‘Body Scam’ to the online romance scam literature that fake daters are establishing trust just for sexual gain, not financial. So, awareness training and avoidance strategies should consider this specific type of attack and cultural relevance.

5.3 Implications and Future Work

In terms of future research, as far as we know, this is the first study to explore the cultural aspects of online dating’s darker side within repressive contexts. While this initial qualitative study sheds light on the subject, further research is going to comprehensively understand online romance scam in a non-western culture akin to Iran where premarital relationships are deemed inappropriate. We observed that even when sexual activities occur without violence, participants describe them as ‘body/sexual scams’ rather than ‘sexual violence,’ influenced by the cultural context of sex taboos. Hence, we introduce the concept of ‘Body Scam’ to the field of online romance scam research and suggest further investigations to establish a universally applicable, comprehensive definition of online romance scams, incorporating a section on ‘body scams’. Furthermore, our initial insights into specific risk factors should be dissected and clarified to demonstrate how the impact of a ‘body scam’ is more significant than that of a ‘money scam.’ We need to explore the irreparable damage it can cause to people in societies that do not belong to Western nations. To accomplish this, we urge the enhancement of empirical studies that investigate ‘body scam’ and its consequences on its victims, particularly within the context of online romance scams in non-Western societies, which are often an under-studied. The results of this study should be integrated into the design of communication tools, such as social media software and systems, aimed at enhancing daters’ safety and providing support for victims.

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